

THE REVOLT OF 1857

Causes • Course • Consequences

a.k.a. *The Sepoy Mutiny* | also called "The First War of Independence" (disputed — see Page 5)

- Headings & Definitions ● Explanations ● Highlighter = Key Facts 🎯 Exam Tip ✖ Common Mistake
🧠 Memory Trick

StudyPlanner

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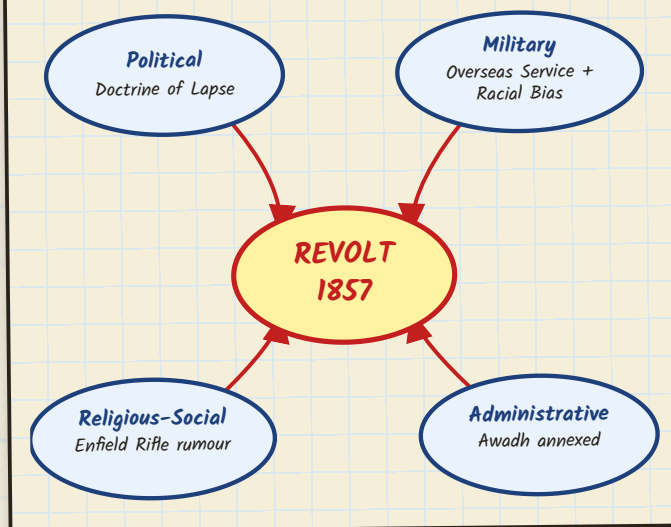
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SETTING THE STAGE

Viceroy at the time of the Revolt: **Lord Canning**. Because it was the soldiers (sepoys) who revolted, 1857 is also known as the **Sepoy Mutiny**.

Fig 1: Causes of the Revolt – Mind Map



1 General Service Enlistment Act

Introduced by **Canning**. It said the **Bengal Army** (mostly Bengali soldiers) could now be sent for **overseas service**.

- "Overseas" = crossing the sea to another country
- Belief at the time (Hinduism): crossing the sea = **loss of one's religion**
- Result: deep resentment began building among the sepoys



Memory Trick

Overseas service → "loss of religion" (as believed then) → Anger in the Army

2 Doctrine of Lapse



Introduced by Lord Dalhousie in **1848**.



Recap: Subsidiary Alliance (tap to expand) ▼



Understand it like this...

Clever moneylenders lend a **small** amount first and repay it **instantly** — building your trust! Next time, they take a **big** amount... and vanish. The British played the same game: first the "harmless" Subsidiary Alliance (small trust), then the kingdom-swallowing **Doctrine of Lapse** (the big one)!



The Rule: If a ruler died **without a natural (biological) heir**, his adopted son got no automatic right to the throne. The British had full discretion — and usually chose to **annex ("lapse")** the kingdom instead.



Memory Trick

"No Blood, No Throne" — the heart of the Doctrine of Lapse!



Common Mistake

Don't mix these two up! **Subsidiary Alliance** = ruler keeps his throne, just accepts British troops & loses foreign policy control. **Doctrine of Lapse** = kingdom is fully annexed if there's no natural heir. Two very different British policies!

States Annexed under Doctrine of Lapse

Year	State
1848	Satara

1849	Sambalpur & Jaitpur
1852	Udaipur
1853	Jhansi



3 Awadh – "The Ripe Cherry"

 Dalhousie's words: "Awadh is a cherry that will drop, ripe, into our mouth!"

- Last Nawab of Awadh: **Wajid Ali Shah** — known for his love of art, music & luxury ("Nawabi shauk"), not administration
- Awadh had accepted the **Subsidiary Alliance in 1801** → British troops were permanently stationed in his court
- Dalhousie got a report prepared alleging "**misgovernance**" — mostly for show
- Result: Awadh **annexed in 1856**, citing misgovernance
- Wajid Ali Shah was arrested & imprisoned in **Kolkata**
- His wife, **Begum Hazrat Mahal**, stayed back in Lucknow — and later **led the 1857 revolt from there!**

Exam Tip

Awadh annexed: **1856** | Reason: **Misgovernance** | Last Nawab: **Wajid Ali Shah** | His wife who led the revolt: **Begum Hazrat Mahal**

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RACIAL BIAS + THE ENFIELD RIFLE

4 Racial Discrimination in the Army

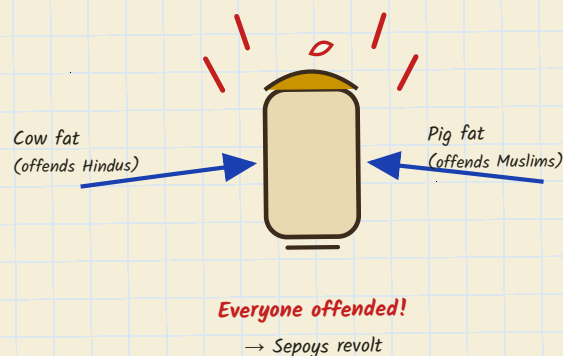
The British Indian Army mixed British and Indian soldiers — Indians vastly outnumbered the British. Indian soldiers faced **racial discrimination** (pay, promotions, respect). This resentment kept simmering quietly...

5 The Enfield Rifle — The Spark! (Immediate Cause)

- New **Enfield rifle** introduced — its cartridge had to be **bitten open with the mouth** before loading
- Rumour spread: cartridges were greased with **cow fat** (sacred to Hindus) and **pig fat** (forbidden in Islam)
- The British officially denied/banned such grease — but the rumour had already spread like wildfire

🔥 Beef offends Hindus. Pork offends Muslims. This cartridge offended everyone — and lit the fire of revolt!

Fig 2: The Cartridge That Offended Everyone



✗ Common Mistake

Don't mix up the dates! Mangal Pandey was hanged on **8 April**, but the Meerut uprising — the real start of the war — began exactly a month later on **10 May 1857**.

July
17

Timeline: Spark to Explosion

● **29 March 1857**

Mangal Pandey (34th Bengal Native Infantry, Barrackpore) attacks his officer in anger over the cartridge issue.

● **8 April 1857**

Mangal Pandey is hanged. News spreads fast among soldiers.

● **24 April 1857**

Soldiers of the **3rd Native Cavalry** (Meerut) refuse to use the new cartridges.

● **9 May 1857**

~90 soldiers court-martialed → **85 dismissed** & sentenced to **10 years'** imprisonment.

● Fellow soldiers revolt and **free their imprisoned comrades** from jail!

● **10 May 1857**

Soldiers march from Meerut towards **Delhi** 🚩



10 MAY 1857 = the day the Revolt truly began!

Delhi – An Old Ruler, A New Cause

- Since the **Battle of Buxar (1764)** and the **Treaty of Allahabad (1765)**, the Mughal ruler was already living under British influence, on a British pension
- At the Red Fort, soldiers declared **Bahadur Shah II** (Bahadur Shah Zafar) their ruler — rejecting British authority
- Bahadur Shah Zafar: old, and not administratively capable
- Real military command: **General Bakht Khan**, aged **81**, led operations from Delhi

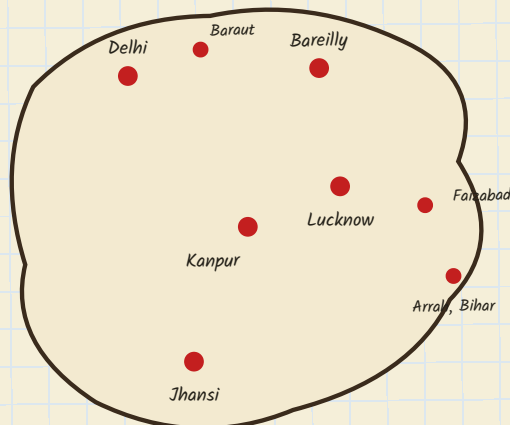
Exam Tip

The General Service Enlistment Act (overseas service) & racial bias are **long-term** military causes; the Enfield Rifle cartridge is the **immediate** cause. Examiners love this distinction!

LEADERS OF THE REVOLT – WHO FOUGHT FROM WHERE?

Centre	Leader
Delhi	Bahadur Shah II (Zafar) / Gen. Bakht Khan
Lucknow	Begum Hazrat Mahal
Kanpur	Nana Saheb
Jhansi	Rani Lakshmibai
Bihar (Arrah)	Kunwar Singh
Bareilly	Khan Bahadur Khan
Faizabad	Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah
UP (Baraut)	Shah Mal

 Fig 3: Where the Revolt Erupted (North India)



 [Nana Saheb – full backstory ▼](#)

✗ Common Mistake

Nana Saheb (led the Kanpur revolt, adopted son of Peshwa Bajirao II) is *not* the same person as **Nana Fadnavis** (the Maratha minister who defeated Raghunath Rao decades earlier). Different people, different eras!

👤 Rani Lakshmibai – full backstory ▼

Quick Notes – Other Leaders

- **Kunwar Singh** — a zamindar (landlord) from Bihar; led the revolt there despite his old age
- **Khan Bahadur Khan** — belonged to the **Rohilla** community; led the revolt from Bareilly
- **Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah** — led the uprising from Faizabad
- **Shah Mal** — led an uprising in the Baraut area of Uttar Pradesh, near Meerut — a name worth remembering!

🎯 Exam Tip

Most-asked pairing in exams: **Jhansi** → **Rani Lakshmibai** and **Kanpur** → **Nana Saheb**.
Learn the table above centre-wise, not leader-wise!

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SUPPRESSION + THE GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ACT, 1858

Centre	Suppressed By
Delhi	John Nicholson
Lucknow	Henry Lawrence
Kanpur	Colin Campbell

Jhansi

Hugh Rose

Gwalior — 1858

Final stand crushed



Memory Trick

Kanpur's famous clock tower / "Bell" at the railway station — remember it, and you'll remember **Colin Campbell** suppressed Kanpur!



General Hugh Rose, after facing her at Jhansi & Gwalior, called Rani Lakshmibai "the best and bravest" of all rebel leaders — practically saying she was "the only man" among them!

The Curtain Falls

- Bahadur Shah II is captured; the **Mughal Empire is formally abolished** — just as the Peshwa title had earlier ended after the Third Anglo-Maratha War
- Exiled to **Rangoon Prison**, Rangoon, Burma (today's **Myanmar**) — he lived out his days there on a British pension

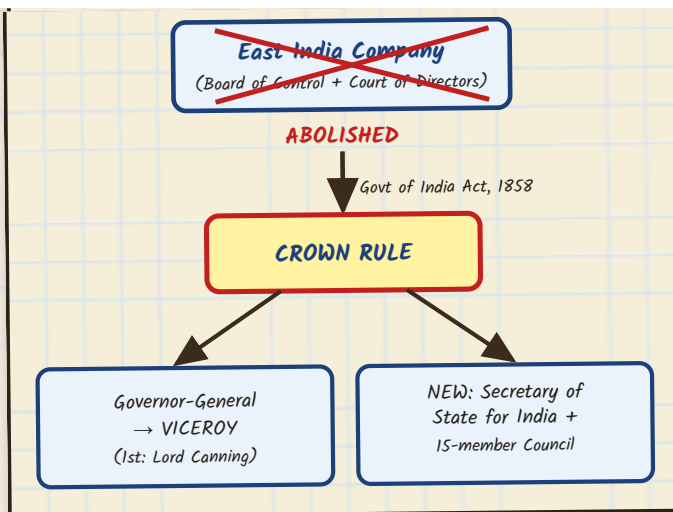


Government of India Act, 1858

1. East India Company **formally abolished**
2. Direct rule of the British Crown begins → "Crown Rule" (also called the **Queen's Proclamation**)
— Monarch: **Queen Victoria** | First Viceroy: **Lord Canning**
3. Title changed: **Governor-General of India** → **Viceroy of India**
4. New post created: **Secretary of State for India**
5. A **15-member Council of India** set up to assist the Secretary of State
6. **Board of Control & Court of Directors** — both **abolished**



Fig 4: Company Rule → Crown Rule



✗ Common Mistake

Governor-General and Viceroy are the **same post**, just renamed in 1858 — Lord Canning was the last Governor-General **and** the first Viceroy!

📖 Evolution of British Governance in India (tap to expand) ▼



Peel Commission

Recommended increasing the ratio of British soldiers to Indian soldiers in the army — so a revolt like 1857 could never happen again.



Exam Tip

Two bodies were abolished together in 1858 → **Board of Control (1784)** + **Court of Directors** — remember both were scrapped in the same stroke!



The East India Company's Journey



EIC formed in 1599 with a charter from **Queen Elizabeth I** for exclusive trade with India. From **Plassey (1757)** to **1858** is almost exactly **100 years** of Company rule — counting from their first trading days (1608), nearly **150 years** of Company presence in India!



WHY WASN'T THE REVOLT FULLY SUCCESSFUL?

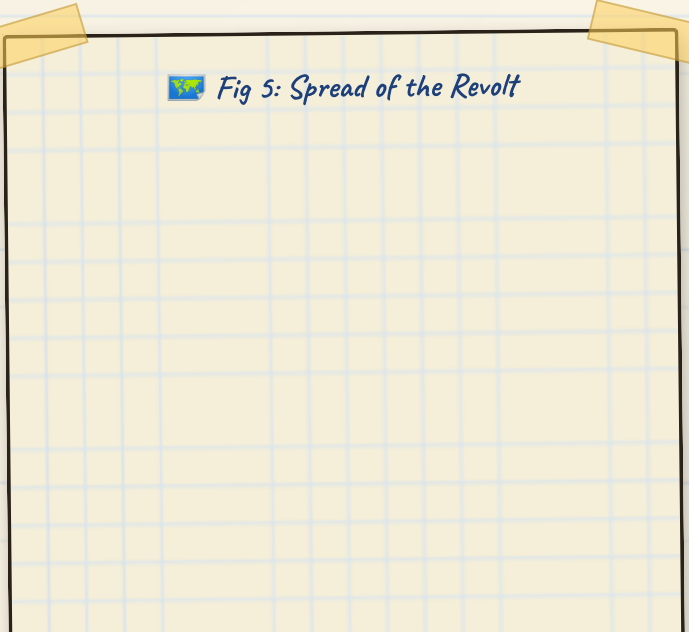
V. D. Savarkar called 1857 "The First War of Independence." But many historians disagree / negate this title. Why?

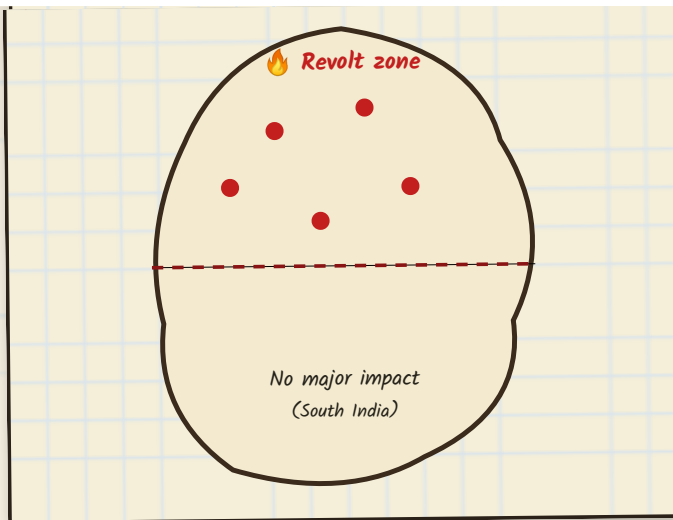
Reasons Historians Give

1. **No unified political vision** — every leader fought for their own region, not a united "India":
 - Rani Lakshmibai → fighting for Jhansi
 - Begum Hazrat Mahal → fighting for Awadh/Lucknow
 - Nana Saheb → fighting for his Maratha interests
2. **No coordination or common leadership** across regions
3. **Limited elite support** — many rich zamindars & the upper class actually preferred British rule, believing it would bring more "civilization" and education than what they saw as the disorder of late Mughal rule
4. **Not pan-India** — mainly confined to North India (Delhi, Lucknow, Kanpur, Jhansi); little to no impact in South India



 Fig 5: Spread of the Revolt





Food for thought

While Europe was making leaps in science (Newton and others), India was caught in regional conflicts. The British didn't particularly promote science in India (they focused more on spreading Christianity) — but Indians did get exposure to new European ideas of governance. At the same time, a recent Oxfam report highlighted the massive scale of colonial-era wealth drained from India — so the full picture is complex, not one-sided.

★ Exam-Ready Summary

- **Long-term causes:** Political (Doctrine of Lapse), Military (racial discrimination), Religious-Social (Enfield Rifle rumour), Administrative (misgovernance annexations)
- **Immediate cause:** Enfield Rifle cartridges
- **Started:** 10 May 1857, Meerut → Delhi
- **Ended:** 1858, Gwalior
- **Result:** End of East India Company rule → start of Crown Rule (Government of India Act, 1858)



Exam Tip

If asked "why did the 1857 revolt fail?" — just recall 4 words: **Disunity, No Coordination, Elite Support (to British), Not Pan-India.**

